

The demo video: shot list and cheat sheet

Date: 2026-09-16 · For the first public video of Seal, Reddit and Hacker News · Print this and tape it to the wall behind the camera.

0. The one rule

Every shot answers one of two questions: “what does this feel like at the kitchen table” or “how do I know it is real”. If a shot answers neither, cut it. Two and a half minutes, three at the most. No slides, no music under the talking, no logo until the end.

1. Before you press record (the day before)

- A build that runs against Production, on every phone in the video. Sign out and back in on each one so nothing from Development is in the keychain (GOTCHAS, Environments).
- The product live in App Store Connect and the Paid Apps agreement signed, so the price screen shows a real price and the seal goes through. If it is not, do not film the paywall; say “one purchase” and show nothing.
- Four YubiKeys: the owner’s, the owner’s backup, one per key holder. Two key holders on camera is the right number: one is not “it takes two”, three is clutter.
- Three phones: the owner (you), key holder one (Mom), key holder two (Dad or Karen). The recipient can be one of the key holders; that is the common case and it saves a phone.
- Fake secrets. A made-up password, a made-up safe combination, a made-up policy number. Never a real one on camera, even blurred.
- Real words in the letter. Three lines you would actually say. That is the part people remember, and it is the part that cannot be faked.
- One printed key holder page, in a real drawer, with a real key on it.
- Charge everything. Turn on Do Not Disturb on every phone. Turn off Bigger text unless the person on camera needs it (then leave it on; it is honest).
- Ask Mom and whoever else is on camera, the day before, whether they are all right being filmed and whether they are all right with the subject. Say it out loud: “This is about what happens after I die. Are you okay filming that?” Their answer is the answer.

2. Camera and sound

- Two setups only. A: you and the phone, chest up, the phone held at chest height angled to camera so the screen reads. B: the table, from above at about forty five degrees, both phones and the keys in frame.
- Screen recordings from the phone itself for every app moment, cut in over the A shot. Turn on the tap indicator (Settings, Accessibility, Touch, AssistiveTouch is not it; use the built in screen recording and keep your thumb visible in the B shot instead). A finger on screen reads better than a dot.
- Lav mic on you. A second mic on the table for the key taps: the tap is a sound, and the brass mark pressing in should have a sound under it. Record room tone for ten seconds.
- Light from a window, phone screens at about 70 percent so they do not blow out. Kitchen light on. No ring light on the phone glass.
- The macro shot: the key touching the top of the phone, slow, once. Shoot it three times. It is your thumbnail.
- Keep the camera still. No handheld walking. Cuts, not moves.

3. The shots, in order, with what you say

Time stamps are targets. Say the lines your own way; keep the facts.

00:00 Cold open, shot A, no title. You hold up one key.

“This is a house key for a letter. When I go quiet for long enough, two of these open it. Not me. Not Apple. Not the company that made the app. Let me show you.”

00:10 Writing, screen recording. Open Seal, Write, pick Mom. Type three real lines. Add one fake secret and say it is fake. Add one photo. Add two “what to do first” steps.

“Only her phone can ever read this. Not the app maker. I am going to show you why in a minute.”

00:40 The handover, shot B. Mom next to you. People, scan each other’s seal. Make her a key holder. She taps her key on your phone. The brass mark presses in. Hand her the key. Put the printed page in the drawer with it.

| *"She holds a key now. She cannot open anything with it. It takes two."*

Then Dad, same thing, faster.

01:05 Seal, screen recording. Tap Seal. Pay (or cut around it).

| *"That is the one thing this app charges for. Once."*

01:15 Time travel, screen recording, and say what it is. Open the orange clock (the debug screen). On screen, say it plainly:

| *"The rule is 90 days of silence, 21 days of warnings, 14 more quiet days. I am not going to make you wait. This is a test screen that moves the clock. It is only in the test build."*

Move to day 100. Show Mom's phone: "Jason has been quiet past the limit." Mom starts the claim. Show your phone: the warning.

| *"Day 100. Mom says she thinks I am gone. My phone warns me every day for three weeks. And if I am alive," tap, "I tap once, and everything stops. No key needed. That is the whole point of the warnings: a long hospital stay looks the same as death from the outside."*

01:50 The opening, shot B and screen recordings. Time travel again, past everything. Mom's phone: "Keys can be tapped now." She taps. Dad taps. Mom's phone opens the envelope: the letter, the photo, the steps. Then stop talking. Fifteen seconds of her reading it. Do not cut away early. If she reacts, that is the video. If she does not, it is still the video.

02:15 The proof, laptop, shot A. Open the capsule file. Run the verifier script. It has no Seal code in it.

| *"Every signature and every timestamp, checked by a script you can read."*

If we go out of business tomorrow, this still opens." Then five seconds of the onboarding's curve figure.

| *"One key is one point on a line. One point could be any line. That is not a policy we wrote. It is arithmetic."*

02:35 Close, shot A. Hold up the key again.

| *"One purchase. No subscription. No account with us. No server that holds your letters. Sealed envelopes for the people you leave behind."*

Title card: Seal, the price, the link. Nothing else.

4. Say these, somewhere in the video or the post

- "Nobody can open one early. Not Apple, not us." Say it twice.
- "Seal does not know I died. It knows I went quiet. The warnings are for the hospital case."
- "There is no email reset, on purpose. That is why there is a backup key." (Show the backup key once.)
- "Key holders are met in person. That is how their key gets pinned."
- "A key holder learns nothing. Not the titles, not who the envelopes are for, not how many."
- "The record outlives us. Here is the file. Here is the script."
- "Face ID works for everything. A hardware key is recommended, never required."

5. Never say these

- "Will." Say "opens", "stops", "does". Every line in the app avoids it, and so should you.
- "When you die." Say "after a long silence" or "when you are gone" as the purpose, paired with the silence.
- "Unhackable", "military grade", "bank level", "zero knowledge". Say what it does; let them say the adjectives.
- "Custodian". It is "key holder".
- "Digital will" or anything with "will" as the legal document. Say "the papers a court makes public".
- Anything about a feature that is not built. No "coming soon".

6. Honesty rules for the shoot

- The time travel screen is shown and named on camera as a test screen. Never cut it so the countdown looks real time.
- Nobody dies in this video. It is "I went quiet". If Mom jokes about it, keep the joke; do not stage grief.

- Real reactions only. If you re-shoot the opening, tell the viewer it is the second take, or use the first take.
- Fake secrets, labelled as fake on screen or in the voice.
- The demo account is a test account. If any real identity or real person's data is on screen, stop and reshoot.

7. The post that goes with the video

Hacker News title: Show HN: Seal, sealed letters and passwords for your family that open after a long silence and two hardware key taps

Reddit title (r/privacy, r/yubikey, r/apple): I built an app so my mom gets my passwords and a letter when I'm gone, with two YubiKeys and no company in the middle. Two minute demo.

The body, in this order: what it is in three sentences; the video; "what it does not do" as a heading (cannot know you died, recipients must be met in person, no email reset, what a key holder can see); how the keys work in one paragraph with a link to docs/SDS.md; the verifier script; the price and the words "no subscription"; what is not built yet (the guided tour, the interview). Then stop.

Your first comment, posted within a minute: the link to the verifier script and the docs folder, and one sentence: "Ask me anything about the threat model. The honest limits are in PRODUCT.md section 8."

8. Cutting

- Cut on the taps. A key tap is a beat; land the edit on it.
- Every screen recording gets two seconds of the finger arriving before the tap. Viewers need to see where you are going.
- No speed ramps on the app. If it is slow, it is slow; cut instead.
- Captions on. Half the people who matter watch with the sound off, and half the people this is for are over sixty.
- Export at 4K, 30 frames per second, and a 1080 by 1920 vertical cut of the same edit for the phone crowd, with the B shot cropped tight on the keys.